‘Golden age’ is of course relative. Golden for whom? Starting from the Gupta age in the fourth century CE, most peasants in northern India lived in a feudal order, toiling to pay taxes to their overlords—from the village thakur to the king—in the *samanta* system. This hierarchy of landed feudatories was obsessed with territorial control and expansion, as well as ‘maintenance of a high social status in Hindu caste hierarchy’, producing a culture of *dana* (religious donation) and temple-building. It was in this social context that the Chandela Rajputs too tried to raise and ‘legitimize their social status by building temples, tanks, and by giving gifts to priestly Brahmins’, which, going by Puranic texts, brought fame and merit to the royals.[14] Historical sources suggest that the elites of Chandela society followed the social conventions typical of other Indian elites of the age. They ‘believed in magic and supernaturalism’, and kept priests and temples happy with gifts of land, the revenue from which was usually tax free. In time, temple officials became landlords, and temples here, as across India, became rich and powerful feudal institutions, acting as ‘landholder, employer, consumer of goods and services, bank, school, museum, hospital and theater’.[15] The upper classes also indulged in ostentation and self-praise and were competitive about acquiring fame and merit (*punya*) through religious works, always aiming to outdo their peers and ancestors.[16]

Most of the twenty-five rediscovered and restored temples in Khajuraho date from this ‘golden age’ starting around 950 CE, though as many as eighty-five temples were built over 250 years, from 900–1150 CE. They were commissioned not just by kings, but also by queens, chieftains in the court and Jain merchants. Scholars aren’t certain what this temple town was called back then, which had many beautiful lakes.Just one inscription offers a clue: Khajuravahaka, or the district of khajura (‘date palm tree’, plentiful in the region). The Persian traveller Alberuni wrote in 1030 CE that the capital of ‘the realm of Jajahuti’ was Kajuraha, but he left no further details.